Activity 3 — Reading Augmented Reality: Changing Our Daily Lives

Part A: The passage

Imagine pointing your phone at an empty corner of your room and seeing a sofa appear there, or following digital arrows overlaid on the pavement to find your way across an unfamiliar city. Both scenes illustrate augmented reality (AR), a technology that combines the real world with digital elements such as images, sounds, animations and information, enhancing the way we experience our surroundings. Unlike virtual reality (VR), which places users inside a completely computer-generated environment, AR adds virtual content to the world we already see.

AR gained momentum in the 2010s with the arrival of devices such as Google Glass and Microsoft HoloLens, early products that hinted at what wearable technology might eventually offer. More recently, Apple's Vision Pro, launched in 2024, marked another milestone. These devices allow users to view and interact with digital content layered over their physical environment, from maps and directions to animated characters and three-dimensional objects. As a result, digital experiences are becoming part of everyday activities rather than something that happens only on a screen.

Businesses have been quick to recognise AR's potential, particularly in marketing and advertising, where companies use it to make shopping more interactive. With their smartphones, customers can see how a sofa would look in their living room or try on make-up virtually before buying it. These tools turn shopping into a more enjoyable activity and, perhaps more importantly, help consumers reach better-informed decisions.

The gaming industry has embraced AR to create more immersive experiences. By combining virtual characters and objects with real surroundings, games allow players to interact with digital elements in their own homes and streets. Behind the scenes, special cameras, sensors and software analyse nearby objects and surfaces so that virtual images blend naturally with the real world. This gives designers new ways to make games feel more lifelike, narrowing the gap between fiction and reality.

Beyond entertainment, AR is reshaping several industries by improving efficiency, saving time and reducing costs. In the automotive sector, manufacturers use it to visualise vehicle designs and examine components before production begins. Repair technicians, meanwhile, can wear smart glasses or headsets that display instructions and useful information while they work, allowing them to keep their hands free.

Education has also benefited. During the COVID-19 pandemic, the expansion of digital learning highlighted the value of interactive teaching tools. AR lets students explore complex subjects such as the solar system, the human body and scientific processes in three dimensions. Seeing these subjects from every angle helps learners grasp difficult concepts. It can also recreate historical places and events, which makes lessons more memorable and encourages deeper engagement.

Looking ahead, AR is expected to play a growing role in many areas of life. In healthcare, it could help medical professionals visualise anatomical structures and plan complex procedures. Architects may use it to display building designs within real locations, and retailers could offer more personalised shopping experiences. Because most people already carry a smartphone capable of running AR apps, the technology has a strong starting point. However, the biggest challenges for widespread adoption are making headsets and glasses lightweight, affordable and comfortable to wear, as well as addressing concerns about privacy and data protection.

Overall, augmented reality is changing the relationship between the digital and physical worlds. What once seemed a novelty is gradually becoming a practical tool in shops, classrooms, workshops and hospitals. As the technology becomes more advanced and more accessible, it is likely to have an even greater influence on how we live, learn and work. That said, the pace of that change will depend on how readily people adopt it, and when it comes to trusting devices that constantly scan our

surroundings, many users will need to be convinced. Whether AR becomes as commonplace as the smartphone will therefore hinge as much on public confidence as on technical progress.

Adapted from: Oleg Khanachivskyi, "Augmented Reality's Potential to Revolutionize Our Everyday Experiences," LitsLink.

Part B: Comprehension Questions

Choose the best answer for each question. Underline the supporting evidence in the passage. If evidence is insufficient, underline the nearest relevant sentence and explain why.

1. The passage opens with two imagined scenes before it defines AR. Which statement best explains how this opening relates to the way the passage ends?

A. The scenes present AR as a tool for shopping and navigation, and the conclusion returns to those two uses as its main future.

B. The scenes show digital content inside real surroundings, anticipating the conclusion's idea of a changing relationship between digital and physical worlds.

C. The scenes illustrate how AR differs from VR, and the conclusion returns to that contrast to argue that AR is the better technology.

2. The second paragraph states that digital experiences are becoming "part of everyday activities rather than something that happens only on a screen." Which statement identifies a gap between the examples given and this conclusion?

A. The passage names devices from the 2010s and 2024 but does not explain why Vision Pro has been more successful than Google Glass.

B. The passage shows digital content layered over the physical environment but does not explain how the devices are able to display it.

C. The passage describes what the devices allow users to do but gives no evidence of how many people actually use them.

3. Which idea links the examples of trying on make-up, examining vehicle components before production, planning complex medical procedures, and displaying building designs in real locations?

A. AR lets people preview how something will look or work before buying, making or doing it, which supports better-informed decisions.

B. AR displays instructions in a worker's field of view, which improves accuracy in jobs where the hands must stay free.

C. AR replaces physical objects with digital versions so convincingly that people no longer need to test the real thing before choosing.

4. The fifth paragraph opens by claiming that AR is reshaping several industries by improving efficiency, saving time and reducing costs. How effectively does the evidence that follows support this claim?

A. It provides convincing evidence that all three benefits have been achieved by showing how AR has transformed industrial processes.

B. It provides insufficient evidence because the examples focus on individual workers rather than on industries as a whole.

C. It illustrates practical uses of AR but does not show that they have actually improved efficiency, saved time or reduced costs.

5. The final paragraph says AR is "gradually becoming a practical tool in shops, classrooms, workshops and hospitals." Which of these places does the rest of the passage support least?

A. Workshops, because repair technicians are mentioned only as an example of what AR could do in the future.

B. Hospitals, because the medical uses described are presented only as possibilities, not as practices that already exist.

C. Classrooms, because the education paragraph relies mainly on the pandemic rather than on examples of AR itself.

6. Which statement offers the best-supported reason why privacy and data protection might be harder to resolve than the other obstacles to widespread adoption?

A. Unlike the device-related obstacles, privacy also depends on public trust in the technology, which technical progress alone cannot establish.

B. Privacy is mainly a concern for smartphone users, whereas the other obstacles concern the headsets and glasses themselves.

C. Privacy must be resolved first, because lightweight and affordable devices cannot be sold until data protection laws exist.